

Brazil → China Cacao Paste Import Checklist

Retail-ready cacao paste / cocoa mass. Working document for Brazil-side and China-side coordination. Prepared for Agroverse / TrueSight DAO operations.

How to use this document

Each item has an owner column — mark **BR** (Brazil side / Matheus, Santos), **CN** (China partner / importer of record), or **BOTH**. Work through items sequentially; the GACC manufacturer registration (Section 2) is the long-lead bottleneck and gates everything else. Realistic first-shipment timeline from cold start: 6–12 months.

0. Product classification — pin this down first

“Retail-ready cacao paste” sits in a gray zone. The HS code determines registration pathway, tariff, applicable Chinese GB standards, and labeling rules. Confirm with the Chinese importer / customs broker **before** any registration work begins.

#	Item	Owner	Done
0.1	Confirm product form: bulk paste (blocks for further processing) vs molded retail bars / tablets ≤2kg.	BOTH	☐
0.2	Confirm HS code with Chinese customs broker. Likely candidates: 1803.10 (paste, not defatted) or 1806.32 (chocolate-form preparations, not filled, ≤2kg).	CN	☐
0.3	Get written tariff quote at the confirmed HS code (MFN duty + 13% VAT + consumption tax if any).	CN	☐
0.4	Confirm whether product is sold to consumers as “chocolate.” If yes, GB 9678.2 (chocolate standard) applies on top of base cocoa rules.	BOTH	☐
0.5	Document ingredient list and process flow (single-origin, ceremonial-grade, any processing aids). Needed for registration and labels.	BR	☐

1. Parties — who needs to be registered where

Three separate registrations are involved. Don't confuse them.

#	Item	Owner	Done
1.1	Identify Brazilian manufacturing facility of record (legal name, address, MAPA registration / SIF or DIPOA number, CNPJ).	BR	☐
1.2	Identify Brazilian exporter of record (may or may not be the same entity as the manufacturer).	BR	☐
1.3	Identify Chinese importer of record (must hold Food Import License from local Customs).	CN	☐
1.4	Identify Chinese consignee and distributor (can be same as importer).	CN	☐
1.5	Confirm Chinese importer is already record-filed with GACC under Decree 249.	CN	☐
1.6	Confirm Chinese importer has imported cocoa / chocolate before (track record reduces inspection friction).	CN	☐

2. GACC manufacturer registration (Decree 248) — long-lead item

Under Decree 248 (effective Jan 1, 2022), the Brazilian **manufacturing facility** must be registered with China's General Administration of Customs (GACC) in the CIPHER system **before** any shipment. Processed cocoa paste / chocolate generally falls outside the 18 “official recommendation” categories, so the self-application pathway should apply — but confirm at item 2.1.

#	Item	Owner	Done
2.1	Confirm registration pathway: self-application (likely for processed cocoa paste / 1806 chocolate) vs recommendation (for unprocessed cocoa beans 1801, which Brazil is NOT currently approved to export to China).	BOTH	☐
2.2	Manufacturer creates an account at China Single Window CIFER portal (cifer.singlewindow.cn).	BR	☐
2.3	Prepare facility documentation package: site photos, process flow diagram, HACCP plan, pest control plan, water and sanitation plan, allergen control plan.	BR	☐
2.4	Prepare Brazilian regulatory proof: MAPA registration, ANVISA food establishment license, valid health and sanitation certificates.	BR	☐
2.5	Prepare food safety management system documentation (ISO 22000 or equivalent strongly preferred — speeds approval).	BR	☐
2.6	Submit CIFER application. Respond to GACC clarification requests within 30 days each time.	BR	☐
2.7	Receive GACC registration number (format: 18-digit code starting with country prefix). This number must appear on every shipment's packaging.	BR	☐
2.8	Note registration validity: 5 years. Calendar the renewal window (apply 3–6 months before expiry).	BR	☐
2.9	Submit the exporter basic file under Decree 249 if the exporter is a separate entity from the manufacturer.	BR	☐

Timeline note: GACC self-application registration typically takes 3–9 months from submission. Plan accordingly. Do not order packaging or commit to any shipping date until the registration number is in hand.

3. Food safety compliance — the cadmium problem

Chinese national food safety standard **GB 2762** sets contaminant limits. Bahian cacao can run high on cadmium due to soil chemistry — this is the most likely shipment-killer. Test against Chinese limits specifically, not just EU Regulation 488/2014.

#	Item	Owner	Done
3.1	Obtain current text of GB 2762-2022 (or latest revision) and identify the cadmium ceiling applicable to cocoa products / chocolate.	BOTH	☐
3.2	Pre-shipment cadmium testing on representative batch by ISO 17025 accredited lab (Brazilian lab acceptable if GACC-recognized; otherwise SGS or Bureau Veritas).	BR	☐
3.3	Pre-shipment lead testing per GB 2762.	BR	☐
3.4	Aflatoxin B1 testing per GB 2761.	BR	☐
3.5	Ochratoxin A testing (relevant for cocoa).	BR	☐
3.6	Microbiology panel per GB 29921 / GB 9678.2 if chocolate: total plate count, coliforms, Salmonella, Staph aureus, mold and yeast.	BR	☐
3.7	Pesticide residue screen (GB 2763 multi-residue method).	BR	☐
3.8	Document any food additives used; verify each is on the GB 2760 permitted list at the permitted level.	BR	☐
3.9	If cadmium results are borderline, plan blending strategy with lower-cadmium origin or de-risk shipment volume.	BOTH	☐

4. Chinese labeling — design before production

Chinese labels must be designed, approved, printed, and applied **at the Brazilian facility before export**. Unlabeled product found at port of entry triggers steep re-labeling charges or rejection. Governing standards: **GB 7718** (general prepackaged food labeling), **GB 28050** (nutrition labeling).

#	Item	Owner	Done
4.1	Chinese importer drafts Chinese-language label content: food name, ingredients, net weight, manufacturer, country of origin, production date, shelf life, storage.	CN	☐
4.2	Add the GACC registration number on both inner and outer packaging (required by Decree 248).	BOTH	☐
4.3	Add Chinese importer name, address, and contact (required).	CN	☐
4.4	Nutrition facts panel per GB 28050 (energy + 4 core nutrients: protein, fat, carbs, sodium).	CN	☐
4.5	Allergen declaration (cocoa is not a major allergen, but cross-contact statements may be needed if the facility handles tree nuts, milk, or soy).	BOTH	☐
4.6	If sold as chocolate: comply with GB 9678.2 naming and composition disclosure rules.	BOTH	☐
4.7	Lot / batch code printed legibly — required for traceability and any future recall.	BR	☐
4.8	Label proofs reviewed by Chinese importer's customs broker BEFORE the print run.	BOTH	☐
4.9	Brazilian facility prints and applies finished labels to retail units AND outer cartons.	BR	☐
4.10	Retain digital and physical label samples for customs presentation.	BR	☐

5. Per-shipment document package

Every single shipment requires this document set. Missing documents at port = cargo held, demurrage charges, or rejection.

#	Item	Owner	Done
5.1	Commercial invoice (HS code, Incoterms, unit price, total value).	BR	☐
5.2	Packing list (gross/net weight per carton, dimensions, lot codes).	BR	☐
5.3	Bill of lading (sea) or air waybill.	BR	☐
5.4	Certificate of Origin issued by Brazilian chamber of commerce.	BR	☐
5.5	Health / Sanitary certificate issued by MAPA in a format accepted by GACC.	BR	☐
5.6	Phytosanitary certificate (cacao is plant-derived).	BR	☐
5.7	Certificate of Analysis from an accredited lab covering heavy metals, mycotoxins, microbiology, and pesticide residues.	BR	☐
5.8	Production date / shelf life declaration on letterhead.	BR	☐
5.9	Ingredient declaration and manufacturing process letter on letterhead.	BR	☐
5.10	Label samples (physical and digital images of both inner and outer packaging).	BR	☐
5.11	Container fumigation / heat treatment certificate if wood pallets are used (ISPM 15 mark on pallets).	BR	☐
5.12	Chinese importer pre-files declaration in China Single Window 3–5 days before vessel arrival.	CN	☐
5.13	All foreign-language certificates accompanied by certified Chinese translations.	CN	☐

6. Logistics & customs clearance

#	Item	Owner	Done
6.1	Select port of entry (Shanghai, Ningbo, Shenzhen, Guangzhou are most experienced with cocoa imports).	CN	☐
6.2	Engage a licensed Chinese customs broker with cocoa / chocolate import experience.	CN	☐
6.3	Confirm cold-chain or temperature-controlled requirement (cacao paste melts — reefer container for tropical-route shipments).	BOTH	☐
6.4	Verify shelf life vs sea transit time (Santos → Shanghai is 35–45 days).	BOTH	☐
6.5	Confirm insurance coverage (CIF or CIP Incoterms recommended for first shipments).	BOTH	☐
6.6	Pre-arrival document submission by importer in Single Window.	CN	☐
6.7	On arrival: customs inspection + CIQ (entry-exit inspection and quarantine). Random sampling likely for first shipments.	CN	☐
6.8	Receive CIQ certificate upon passing inspection (3–7 days typical; up to 14 if physical inspection).	CN	☐
6.9	If product fails inspection: technical treatment under GACC supervision, return to exporter, or destruction at importer's cost.	BOTH	☐
6.10	Track tariff payment, VAT (13%), and any consumption tax through the importer.	CN	☐

7. Post-import & ongoing obligations

#	Item	Owner	Done
7.1	Importer maintains traceability records for 6 years minimum (lot-level, customer-level).	CN	☐
7.2	Both sides retain copies of all CoAs, certificates, and lab tests for 6+ years.	BOTH	☐
7.3	Establish recall procedure with named responsible parties on each side.	BOTH	☐
7.4	Monitor GACC notices for rule changes or product alerts (Decree 280 dynamic risk system takes effect June 1, 2026).	BOTH	☐
7.5	Calendar GACC registration renewal: apply 3–6 months before the 5-year expiry.	BR	☐
7.6	Track product complaints and SAMR inquiries; respond within required windows.	CN	☐
7.7	If any change to facility, recipe, or process: notify GACC and amend the registration.	BR	☐

Critical-path summary — tackle in this order

1. **Classify** the product (Section 0) — determines everything downstream.
2. **Test cadmium** on a representative Brazilian batch (item 3.2). If it fails GB 2762, the rest is wasted effort. Do this in parallel with classification.
3. **Confirm Chinese importer of record** (Section 1) — they file in Single Window and own clearance.
4. **Start GACC manufacturer registration** (Section 2) — the 3–9 month critical path.
5. **Design Chinese labels** in parallel (Section 4).
6. **Build the per-shipment doc package template** (Section 5) so the first real shipment is a copy-edit not a scramble.
7. **Ship a small first lot** — treat it as a system test, not a revenue shipment.

This checklist is operational guidance compiled from GACC Decrees 248 and 249, GB national food safety standards, and current public-information sources as of May 2026. It is not legal advice. Confirm specifics with a licensed Chinese customs broker and, where useful, a Brazilian export agent familiar with the China lane before committing capital or production capacity. Standards and

approved-origin lists change — verify before each registration cycle.